



International Women's Day 2020

I am Generation Equality: Realising Women's Rights



International Women's Day on 8 March provides an important opportunity to celebrate women's achievements for greater equality. This year's theme for International Women's Day is "I am Generation Equality: Realising Women's Rights".

On this day in 1857, women factory workers in New York City protested against long working hours, child labour, low wages, and disparity in payments. Later in 1910, during the second International Conference of Working Women in Copenhagen, German women's rights activist Clara Zetkin proposed that March 8 be celebrated as Women's Day all over the world. The conference of over 100 women from 17 countries approved the proposal unanimously. Following this decision, International Women's Day was observed for the first time in Austria, Denmark, Germany and Switzerland in 1911. Since then, International Women's Day has been observed as a global day. Bangladesh celebrates the day for accelerating gender parity.

International Women's Day is significant this year as the global community will mark the 25th anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, 1995. Moreover, a five-year milestone will be reached towards achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Over the past few decades, Bangladesh has made significant progress in reducing its existing gender disparity. According to the Global Gender Gap Report 2020, Bangladesh ranks top amongst South Asian countries in reducing gender gap. Bangladesh has also made significant advancement in improving Human Development Indicators (HDI) in 2018 and is ranked 135th out of 189 countries. The HDI index reveals that Bangladesh has advanced a lot in achieving gender parity in primary and secondary school enrollment. The country now has a reduced maternal mortality rate of 176 per 100,000 live births whereas the number is 232 in developing countries. Bangladesh has experienced a sevenfold increase in its contraceptive prevalence rate (CPR) from 8% in 1975 to 62% in 2014.

However, such achievements gets marred because of the increasing incidents of sexual harassments and violence against women and children. Bangladesh has the fourth highest prevalence rate of child marriage in the world, and it ranks first amongst the South Asian countries. According to

UNICEF, 52% of Bangladeshi girls are married off before the age of 18. The country is also struggling to reduce the drop-out rate of girls in the secondary education level.

Sexual harassment in public spaces still remains rampant. A study conducted by BRAC and BRAC University revealed that 94% women have experienced sexual harassment in verbal, physical and other forms while commuting in public transport. Widespread incidents of sexual violence like rape have raised serious concerns over the safety of women and children in Bangladesh. A report by child rights advocacy group Bangladesh Shishu Adhikar Forum revealed that at least 1,005 incidents of child rape were recorded in 2019, which is up by 76% than that of the previous year.

The Government of Bangladesh is committed to eliminate all forms of discrimination and violence against women. To fulfill this commitment, Bangladesh adopted a number of policies and acts like National Women Development Policy 2011, National Children Policy 2011, Domestic Violence Prevention and Protection Act 2010, Dowry Prohibition Act 2018, Child Marriage Restraint Act 2017, National Plan of Action to Prevent Violence Against Women and Children 2018-2030, National Plan of Action to Prevent Child Marriage 2018-2030 etc.

National toll-free helpline number 109 has been launched to provide immediate support to victims and links up survivors to relevant agencies. However, gaps and challenges still remain while women keep struggling to get access to justice. Lengthy legal procedure, case backlog, lack of evidence and an unfriendly interrogation process hinder survivors to get justice.

Despite commendable progress, gender-based violence remains the foremost obstacle to achieving equality for women. It is very important to ensure rapid prosecution of perpetrators as well as to change the traditional patriarchal mindset of people. The future generations need to be oriented to positive masculinity through family practices of values and socialisation process. It is also important to introduce them to 'positive men' as role models whom they can follow. The national curriculum and textbooks need to be more gender responsive.

The theme of this year clearly addresses the youth as changemakers to end violence against women and promote women's empowerment. It is only possible when the youth are confident in their own abilities and they are respectful towards women's rights. Since its inception, BRAC has been working relentlessly with a vision to build a world free from all forms of exploitation and discrimination. Let us encourage each other to practice responsive behaviours by recognising the ideological spirit of International Women's Day.

Join us to celebrate International Women's Day 2020 around the world to prove that equality for women is progress for all!